

THE HAPPINESS ISSUE

It's 8 am on a foggy and cold day in Bicharpur, a nondescript village in Madhya Pradesh's Shahdol district. But around 70 kids from the ages of four to 18 have lined up to train and play football—a sport that has given Bicharpur a separate identity. The passion for football among residents has earned the village the epithet of 'Mini Brazil'.

Multiple persons have nurtured football in Bicharpur—once known for brewing illicit liquor—but the opening credit goes to Suresh Kunde, 65. Born in a marginalised Scheduled Caste community, Kunde as a youngster played football at the Railway ground in Shahdol town. In Bicharpur, Kunde began exhorting young villagers to take up the game. The first to respond was Ketram Singh Gond, 57, a labourer who played football on the side. Both Kunde and Ketram roped in their families. Over two decades later, the Kunde family has had 15 members who have played football at the state and national levels. Ketram Singh's brood has had 10 members playing football, in school and inter-university tournaments at the state and national levels. The most prominent footballer from Bicharpur was Kunde's son Neelendra, who was called for the India team camp. Recognition of Bicharpur's footballing prowess came in the form of PM Narendra Modi's glowing mention of it in a July 2023 episode of *Mann ki Baat*.

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

↘ Once known for brewing illicit liquor, a localised footballing revolution has seen Bicharpur emerge as a powerhouse of the game

↘ Bicharpur has produced around 40 state and national level footballers, both men and women. Inspired by the 'mini Brazil', around 1,200 clubs have been formed in Shahdol district

↘ The Sports Authority of India has started a feeder centre at the village to train promising players

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"Suresh Kunde was Bicharpur's first coach and pulled kids out of their houses to play football," says former sarpanch Sheetal Singh Tekam. Sadly, the man who lives for football is now paralysed and bedridden. The walls in his room are papered with certificates and photos. One of them shows a young and ponytailed Kunde in his prime.

However, for the missionaries of the Beautiful Game, those early days in the 1990s were challenging. None of the players had kits and there wasn't a suitable playing ground. Around 15 years ago, a local, Safdar Husain, himself a footballer, gave land for a ground. "My only condition was that if I see cricket stumps, I will retake possession," says Husain. Later, the government allotted land for a football ground and corporates, especially Ultratech, stepped in to sponsor kits and facilities.

Today, football in Bicharpur is not just an all-male preserve—in dodges and dribbles and in tackles and free-kicks, girls are often faring better. "My father, Ketram Singh, once took my sister Rajni to play. Everyone laughed at him.... Rajni eventually went on to play in 14 national tournaments," says Anil Singh, a former national level player himself. The third generation in the family—Aneedev, 6; Harsh, 15 and Vinay, 8—also plays football and met PM Modi during his visit to Shahdol in July 2023. "Each of the nearly 150 families in Bicharpur has someone playing football," claims Tekam. Now, inspired by Bicharpur, around 1,200 clubs have been formed in Shahdol through the government's 'football kranti' initiative.

In September, at the state-level Khelo MP Youth Games, the girl's football team of Shahdol division hammered Jabalpur division by 24-0 and went on to win the tournament. Of the 18 girls in the Shahdol team, nine are from Bicharpur. The Rewa University girl's team, with seven players from Bicharpur, has won the inter-university tournament for three years in a row.

In August 2023, the Sports Authority of India opened a feeder centre at Bicharpur and has appointed a local girl, Laxmi Sahees, as coach. After a talent search, 20 boys and 20 girls have been selected.

At the practice session, Aneedev sports a Ronaldo jersey, while Vinay wears an Argentinian jersey with Messi's name on the back. "My hero is Ronaldo, but I want to play for India," says Aneedev after scoring a goal through the cones that mark the goal post. The kids at Bicharpur dream big. ■